How To Abandon Self View

(from Hillside Hermitage talk no.287)

Ajahn Nyanamoli: What is the result of a successful practice?

Q: Not being bothered as much.

Nm: In that case, what can happen is that when people get inspired to practice, they end up constructing an environment around them whereby nothing bothers them; where everything is at arm's length; and it feels like their practice is succeeding because they don't sufer as much factually. They end up measuring their success by how much better they can manage their sufering. Which, sufce to say, is quite unfortunate.

How would you know that you are practicing correctly? How is not being bothered practically measured in terms of the insight talked about in the suttas?

Q: What about if your mind moves less on account of the thought of dying?

Nm: What do the suttas defne as the culminating insight required for a mind to not move on account of dying?

Q: Anicca.

Nm: What's the insight that anicca and dukkha culminate in?

Q: Anatta.

Nm: Exactly, that is the culminating insight. The complete cessation, frst of self-view, then of conceit. And when that is completely gone without any trace- you couldn't sufer even if you want to.

Q: Is the measure that the less somebody takes things personally, the more they are progressing in the practice?

Nm: It could be. But you also have psycho-therapeutical methods that teach you how ‘not to take things personally’. But you’re taking that personally. So, it has to be an actual insight into anatta. And anatta is not something you can stumble upon accidentally. That’s why you need the voice of another and yoniso manasikara (concurrent attention) based on sense restraint.

It’s a factual, irreversible insight. Seeing anicca and dukkha is just so that you can experience the anatta.

"There are monks, these two conditions for the arising of the right view. Which are the two? The voice of another, and yoniso manasikara.

These, monks, are the two conditions for the arising of the right view." - An2.118–129

Q: You can say my mind won’t be bothered by even the thought of dying. But anatta is more fundamental than becoming so mentally strong that nothing bothers you.

Nm: Yes. That’s a necessary prerequisite for insight. As the Buddha said during his life, some teachers could help one establish neither-perception-nor-non-perception, which means you are pretty much unbothered by anything inferior to that. But only in the dispensation of the Buddha could one attain the anatta part.

The suttas say that an Arahant’s mind doesn’t get overwhelmed by things- an Arahant’s mind overwhelms things. That is the factual strength, without which one couldn’t understand and fully develop the anatta.

"When a bhikkhu dwells thus, (restraint, recollected, wise, and liberated), he overwhelms forms; forms do not overwhelm him. He overwhelms sounds; sounds do not overwhelm him. He overwhelms

odors; odors do not overwhelm him. He overwhelms tastes; tastes do not overwhelm him. He overwhelms tactile objects; tactile objects do not overwhelm him. He overwhelms mental phenomena; mental phenomena do not overwhelm him. This is called a bhikkhu who overwhelms forms, who overwhelms sounds, who overwhelms odors, who overwhelms tastes, who overwhelms tactile objects, who overwhelms mental phenomena—one who overwhelms and who is not overwhelmed. He has overwhelmed those evil unwholesome states that defle, that lead to being, that bring trouble, that result in sufering, and that perpetuate birth, aging, and death.

"It is in this way that one is uncorrupted." - Sn35.243

But say you have been sense restrained, seeing the danger in the slightest fault, guarding the sense doors, keeping the precepts, living in solitude. If you are meeting the requirements to start seeing and abandoning attavada(self-view),... what then is self-view? Is it something that would occur, and you can interpret it in hindsight? Or do you need to know where to look for it, to see it and recognize it? What's the necessary basis for anatta?

Q: Seeing atta (self).

Nm: Yes. What is atta then?

Q: You can't put it in front of you- it's always peripheral.

Nm: Yes, the properties of atta- the sense of self- are that it's not directly visible. You can't access it through your senses. You can't observe it with your fve senses, and you can't say 'this is my "Self" that I am relating to'. It's always ambiguous. What else? Do you have the experience of when that self is not there?

Q: No.

Nm: It's always there to some degree. Sometimes it might feel clearer or more ambiguous. But that sense of self -the center of experience- is always there. Do you see it right now as we speak- the sense of self enduring on its own- somehow ambiguously lingering?

Q: To some degree. Accepting its allusivity is important when it comes to seeing it on its own terms.

Nm: That's the key there. The way to see it is on its own terms. That is what solitude and the practice of mindfulness are.

Not how to make it into an object of observation that I think it should be.

<u>The Present Memory</u>

Mindfulness is the memory of your present experience. By abandoning the views of mindfulness being concentration on the present moment you realize that there's nothing complicated about it. Having the memory of the present moment while we speak- that's what mindfulness is. The practice of memory here and now.

It's like a diferent angle of attending to what is directly attended in front of me- yoniso manasikara. If I ask you to recall a memory, how would you do that? Focus on sensations and your breathing? No, it would be the opposite. You would de-focus on what you were focusing on, to recall or recollect what is there.

That point of view- of memory- whether it's the memory of this second or the memory of 10 years ago, is the same point of view. It's the point of view that you can use to observe the present experience; at the same time, you are (indirectly) in the present experience. It's the background of your current absorbed attention. It's the 'point of view' of your senses. It's where the mind is.